

GP Governance Revision Package

Introduction

Countries' methods of governance are shaped by a range of historical and socio-economic factors.

Governance is about negotiation and balance between tensions. These tensions can be between individual freedom and social stability, between needs of majority and minorities, as well as between how resources are managed and allocated over the long term and short term.

Quotes

"Good governance should be like air. Its existence need not be discussed but its absence would make a huge difference." – Pras Hanth

- Just as the quote by the famous Indian businessman astutely points out, governance makes a huge impact on its people's lives.

1. Media and Governance

Possible questions:

1. The internet has made governance an inherently more challenging task. Discuss.
- 2.

Stand: Yes, has made more challenging

Intro

TS1 (No)

The digital age has undoubtedly led to **greater accessibility of information**, making it easier for politicians to govern as they are **better positioned and better equipped to understand the needs and concerns of all citizens**.

Critical analysis

- The creation of social media accounts by prominent politicians has allowed citizens to contact and voice out their opinions swiftly by simply dropping them a direct message or reply.
- This has allowed politicians to **converse in real time** about issues rather than after decisions have been made. This allowed citizens to have a **greater role to play in policy making**, allowing the policy to be better suited for their needs.
A sense of propinquity between politicians and the public is also created which strengthens **empathy and transparency** in policy making.

Examples

- Opposition politicians from the Workers Party have received gushing praises from international public relations companies like Gushcloud for their effective social media engagement during the 2020 Singapore General Elections.

The use of colourful infographics on the various social media platforms such as Facebook, Twitter and Instagram have allowed the Workers Party to convey its various proposals and rationales.

Such effective utilization of the internet and new media has allowed the Workers Party to win a record 10 seats in Parliament and deal a powerful blow to the PAP's iron grip over the country.

TS2 (Made it more challenging):

The Internet has enhanced the democratic process by creating a **well-informed population, improving transparency**, which in turn empowers voters to make a fully informed choice on their selection of leaders.

Critical analysis

- The improved flow of information creates a **more discerning electorate that demands authenticity and credibility** from their politicians. Additionally, it also creates a more educated electorate that understands which politician best represents their interests.

Examples

- The attempt by the People's Action Party to smear the reputation of Workers Party candidate Raeesah Khan during the 2020 Singapore General Elections ultimately fell flat as she received strong online support from digital savvy electorate. Many voters online expressed solidarity with Khan with hashtags such as #IStandWithRaeesah which ultimately led to her being the youngest elected Member of Parliament in Singapore.
- In distinct contrast, **having uninformed voters would result in disastrous outcomes** as evidenced in the Brexit conundrum. During the night of the historic decision in 2016, data from Google Trends encapsulated the ignorance of many Britons as two of the top searches were "What is Brexit?" and "What will happen if we leave the EU?".

TS3 (Made it more challenging):

The digital age has made it more difficult to govern as the **rapid dissemination of unfiltered information** allowed the **spread of liberal ideologies** which may **run counter to the official narrative or mandate**, threatening the rule by the government.

Critical analysis

- The increased connectivity brought by the Internet has allowed for an international exchange of culture, beliefs and ideologies which **threatened to shoot down several cherished sacred cows**.

Examples

- The **lack of traditional gatekeeping in digital platforms** has allowed the pro-LGBT movement in the US to catch on in Singapore, with more people becoming aware of issues never thought of in a traditionally conservative society. This has led to the organisation of Pink Dot as well as greater protests to laws such Section 377A, and calls to legalise same-sex marriages.
- Despite the Trump Administration's attempts to frame the decision to leave the Paris Agreement as one that could save America "close to 3 trillion in lost GDP and 6.5 million

industrial jobs, it was widely debunking by online fact checkers revealed that the US GDP would only be negatively affected by 0.2% until 2025.

TS4 (Made it more challenging):

The Internet has led to the **proliferation of extreme ideals** as well as **cybercrime** which undermine national security and social order.

Critical analysis

- The use of online propaganda by religious fundamentalists have allowed them to recruit and radicalise members from many Western nations. This has incited a vicious cycle of hatred and violence, destabilising numerous countries from within.
- The emergence of the Internet has brought about a whole new type of criminal activity, cybercrime.

Examples

- ISIS's strategic use of social media advertising demonstrates the resourcefulness of the organisation, mobilizing an estimated 40,000 foreign nationals from 110 countries to join the group. ISIS also utilizes advertising propaganda through their online magazine Inspire, transmitting dangerous ideologies to vulnerable communities.
- The internet has been widely utilized as a key platform for conducting criminal activities. The rise of closed source websites within the realms of the Darkweb has allowed criminal syndicates to operate effectively efficiently under the cloak of anonymity granted by the Internet.

This **complicates law enforcement** and poses a **threat to national security**, challenging the government in their regulation of such illicit activities.

Counter (Not more challenging):

Detractors may argue that such arguments are **overly nihilistic**, as capable governments are still able to effectively respond to such threats through **increased surveillance**, the Internet can be utilized as a weapon to fight back against crime itself.

Examples

- In 2020, a Singaporean who transferred \$450 to ISIS was sentenced to 33 months of jail under the Internal Security Act, which work hand in hand with the Cyber Security Agency, employing techniques similar to those used to track child-pornography rings and other kinds of cybercrimes.
Since 2002, close to 90 individuals have been detained for terrorism-related activities, exemplifying the how effective use of the internet can indeed bring cybercrime activities down.

Rebuttal

However, such arguments are being overly simplistic and fail to recognise the constraints that the government face in their response to online threats.

Critical analysis

- Governments do not have **unbridled discretion** in tackling these illegal activities as they cannot intrude excessively into the privacy of citizens.

Examples

- The establishment of the US Patriot Act from the 911 attacks, is aimed to prevent similar terrorist attacks from happening in the future. However, the Snowden revelations has caused outcry at how much of such privacy is being invaded.
The **tension between individual freedom and amount of power invested in the state** hence becomes harder to navigate, as **the compromise between privacy and security becomes an issue of contention**.
- Western critics of the China's social credit system and the Great Firewall often commented that the commitment to regulating behaviour and mass surveillance is **Orwellian and dystopian** in nature.

TS 5 (Made it more challenging):

The proliferation of **fake news** makes it difficult for citizens to discern facts from fiction, creating conflicts in society and hindering governance.

Critical analysis

- The concept of anonymity as well as the sheer amount of information available online has led to the **difficulty in identifying and verifying first-hand accounts**, allowing fake news to quickly spiral out of control.
- This eventually **culminate in social tensions between communities and the government**, upsetting the political stability as citizens demand for action but not the full picture.

Examples

- The Protection from Online Falsehoods and Manipulation Act (POFMA) has been invoked in cases which primary threaten the political stability of Singapore.
A few cases involved opposition parties who alleged that the Government mismanaged public funds, abused police powers and discriminated against Singaporeans in favour of foreigners.

2. Governance and Responsibility

- Economic responsibility
- Social responsibility

Possible questions:

1. Government policies should be concerned mainly with economic progress. Do you agree?

Stand: Yes \$

Intro

“The measure of a civilised country is how it treats its weakest members.” – Plato

- **Economic progress often serves as the cornerstone for governance of a country** as it grants the government the **latitude to implement other policies**. However, just as the oft-cited quote from Plato precisely reiterates that government policies should also be concerned with other aspects of the country, such as meeting the needs of minority communities.

TS1 (No)

Prioritising rapid economic growth can generate certain negative side-effects on certain minority communities that governments need to address.

Critical analysis

- While economic progress is placed on a pedestal by governments, it nonetheless comes with its detriments as economic progress often comes with **inevitable widening of social inequalities**, excluding certain communities within society.

Examples

- Though Singapore has an impressive economic growth track record, with its incredible speed of development earning it the name of one of Asia’s Four Tigers, it also has one of the world’s **highest Gini coefficients**, which is a figure measuring the extent of income inequality in a country.
The bottom 10% of Singaporean households earn an average of \$570 a month while the top 10% of Singaporean households earn \$13,570 a month.
- China’s adoption of artificial intelligence to boost economic growth as resulted in the **loss of jobs for more than 7.1 million blue collared workers, exacerbating income inequality**.
- The use of large stimulus packages and raised debt ceilings to maintain economic growth in America since the 2008 Financial Crisis has pushed the United States national debt to a record high of \$591 billion in 2019. Some economist believe that the government may be forced to raise taxes in the future to repay the debts, compromising the well-being of future generations.

TS2 (No)

An obsession with economic gains often comes at the expense of **environmental damage**.

Critical analysis

- When industrialisation and modernisation are made a top priority, environmental concerns and conservation inevitably become marginalised.

Examples

- India has enjoyed a GDP growth rate of 6% to 7% since 1991. Yet, India is also notorious for the vast environmental damage that economic development has brought within the country. 7 of 10 most polluted countries in the world belongs to India, and the Ganges river is one of the most polluted in the world.

Rebuttal

However, such arguments are being too parochial as such detrimental outcomes are only confined to specific scenarios where the government does little to nothing in response to environmental damage, as often times, environmental degradation can be mitigated.

Critical analysis

- These negative impacts can be easily overcome should governments choose to redirect a portion of their financial gains to invest in environmental protection and conservation.
- Only in situations where the government totally ignore the importance of environmental protection, will such detrimental outcomes **snowball** and **create larger-than-life problems** that become too difficult to solve.

Examples

- For instance, since 2012, Singapore's Housing Development Board has rolled out a \$31 million plan to install solar panels in 30 neighbourhoods. The Solar Energy Institute of Singapore partnered up with the Economic Development Board and the National Research Foundation of Singapore in their research in the solar energy sector. **Many initiatives to protect the environment only came about because of the economic gains that Singapore has achieved which then pave the way.**

TS3 (Yes)

Economic progress should be prioritised as it opens the doors for governments to ensure and safeguard the physical and non-material well-being of the citizens, ensuring **social stability**.

Critical analysis

- It is undeniable that before other objectives can be actively pursued, a healthy and growing economy must first be a key goal to achieve as the **well-being and quality of life** of the citizens should be the top priority of the government.
- **Economic gains and material improvements do much to remove the many grievances** that people in more impoverished countries experience, such as poverty, lack of housing, unemployment and diseases.
- **Such social ills** have the potential to result in social instability.

Examples

- As one of the four Asian Tigers, Singapore has the world's 3rd highest GDP per capita, the world's busiest port and the world's 4th largest financial hub.

Decades of strong and consistent economic growth has allowed Singapore to accumulate a **large national reserve** which allows it to spend on **improving social welfare**.

Singaporeans enjoy high literacy rates (97.5% IN 2019), low infant mortality rate (0.15% in 2020) and low crime rates (600 per 100,000 in 2019). Such remarkable results are arguably a direct result of Singapore's excellent economy.

- Similarly, China's economy **grew by leaps and bounds**, lifting 800 million citizens out of rural poverty, enhancing their standards of living. With a growing economy comes **improved public amenities and infrastructure**, which in turn leads to a higher standard of living for its citizens.

TS4 (Yes)

A strong economy ensures **political stability** as it allows for the implementation of **long-term policies** that further the nation's progress, hence, it should be the primary focus of government policies.

Critical analysis

- There is often a **sympiotic relationship between economic and political stability** which forces governments to maintain economic progress consistently.
- Achieving economic stability will decrease the chances of political backlash occurring, thus making governance a much easier, smooth-sailing task.

Examples

- The decline in price of petrol led to the collapse of Venezuela's oil dominant economy, which then ushered in an unprecedented political crisis in 2017, which no end in sight.
- This is in stark contrast with the People's Action Party of Singapore.
The consistent achievement of economic progress has allowed the PAP to fulfil its social contract with its citizens where Singaporeans surrender certain civil liberties and individual freedoms in exchange for fundamental guarantees like security, education and affordable housing.
Economic prosperity achieved by the PAP has arguably allowed the party to maintain a **majority in Parliament for 61 years**.

Conclusion

- Ultimately, prioritisation must be practiced in a manner that strikes an appropriate balance between preserving economic development and the other responsibilities of the government. Whilst governments are justified in economic development, they must not over-commit.
- Given the examples discussed in this essay, I agree that economic development should be considered a priority of any government.

2. Government needs to make unpopular decisions, do you agree?

Stand: Agree

Intro

“If you want to be popular, do not try to be popular all the time. Popular government does not mean that you do popular things all the time. And if we flinch from the unpopular, we are in deep trouble.” – Lee Kuan Yew, founding father of Singapore

- Elected governments often face the dilemma of choosing what is popular and what is right. Nonetheless, just as the founding father of Singapore astutely observed, capable governments must have the will to make unpopular decisions that will ultimately serve the country in the long run.

TS1 (No)

Some may argue that it is **the very nature and basis of democracy** for the government to be elected by the people, for the people.

Critical analysis

- As an extension of this fundamental principle, they claim that **governments should always make decisions that are popular with society** as it is only then that a government can have the mandate of its people and represent their views. Such individuals point to unpopular decisions such as the raising of taxes in the United States or the tightening of government fiscal policy in the countries of Portugal and Ireland. For governments to fulfil their responsibility, individuals of this view believe that they should act in accordance with the majority's view in society.

Rebuttal

However, such a view is **myopic** as it does not consider **the government's responsibility to its people to create and sustain a society** that is not just agreeable to its people but one which is stable and secure.

Critical analysis

- Considering how the public might not be fully in the know about threats that society faces, or the considerations involved in changing government policy, a good government still needs to make unpopular decisions.

Examples

- In the midst of economic collapse, the governments of Germany, France and Italy have a duty to their citizens to make decisions that are in the best interest of the economy even if they are not popular. Merkel's German administration, the Christian Democratic Union, recently avoided committing to a combined undertaking of government-backed securities under a joint-Eurobond scheme due to local political pressure. The inability of governments to take the unpopular path is one reason why little improvement has been made in the European Financial Crisis. Hence, it is clear that to protect the interests of society, governments, which are privy to information that the public may not have, have the responsibility to make unpopular decisions that are in the interests of the nation.

TS2 (No)

Detractors may argue that governments should always make popular decisions **to maintain the mandate of its people, appealing to the majority voters.**

Critical analysis

- Arguments made by the consequentialism school of thought would argue that **the corollary of being an elected government** is that popular decisions must be made by the government in order to appeal to the voters such that they are more likely to retain its mandate at the ballot box.
As a result, policies often appeal to citizens' interests.

Examples

- The Singaporean government has structured three cash pay-outs for all adult Singaporeans during the coronavirus pandemic. This popular decision arguably contributed to the government's subsequent re-election during the 2020 General Elections.
- Tellingly, the Trump administration's decision to postpone the second round of stimulus cheques for American households led to his approval rating dropping from 54% to 48% based on a CNN poll.

TS3 (Yes)

However, the true hallmark of an outstanding government lies in its **willingness to make right rather than expedient decisions,** especially when these decisions prove unpopular.

Critical analysis

- The vast resources and information available to the government allows them to operate with **far greater foresight and knowledge** than the average citizen. This obligates them to make far-sighted decisions even when such choices are considered unwelcoming.
The fact is, governments are often **more wise and considers a broader picture when it comes to policy making** while an average citizen may only be interested in his or her benefit.

Examples

- SG GST**: The Singapore government has remained adamant on its stance to raise the Goods and Service Tax from 7% to 9% between 2021 and 2025 despite stiff opposition from the general public. Whilst unpopular, this decision proved to be necessary as it provided a way to replenish the shrinking reserves after much fiscal stimulus was provided to fight the economic impact of the coronavirus pandemic.
- SG & China COVID**: China and Singapore's seemingly stark strict response to the COVID-19 pandemic with the early shutdown of borders and compulsory stay home notices is a prime example of unpopular, but effective and responsible governance.
While many local as well as international critics labelled such decisions as being over-paranoid and unnecessary, such caution of the Singapore government proved to be right as it led to the fortunate outcome of a direct suppression of the pandemic, with one of the lowest community infections rates in the world.

TS4 (Yes)

Governments should also not be afraid to make unpopular decisions, especially when it comes to **environmental protection and preservation**.

Critical analysis

- **Popular sentiment in the business industry may run contrary to rationality.**
- Very often, there are strong political lobbies by various industries for government support and investment. Governments need to ensure that it is not just the loudest or most popular industries which get the benefits.
- Governments should not over prioritise economic gains but instead aim to develop environmental policies.

Examples

- Despite the **strong oil and coal lobby in America**, the government needs to make the unpopular decision to channel more resources to environmentally sustainable alternatives. Although this **may prove unpopular at present as it rewards little at the start**, such decisions **improve environmental sustainability in the long run**, creating new opportunities for foreign direct investments and better living environment for the people. With the creation of jobs and opportunities, concerns about the loss of jobs in the oil and coal sector will become less relevant in the future.

TS5 (Yes)

Unpopular decisions are also necessary for governments to legislate effectively to **maintain social order**, eliminating dangers which threaten the social fabric of society.

Critical analysis

- In the highly digitalized world today, the internet has allowed for the **proliferation of extreme ideologies** as well as **cybercrime**, making it difficult for governments to govern.
- The government utilizes the internet as a weapon to mitigate such problems, implementing surveillance and censorship on online activities. This, unfortunately, is seen by many as an intrusion of their privacy and human right.
- However, the effectiveness of such measures is also proven.

Examples

- Western critics of the China's social credit system and the Great Firewall often commented that the commitment to regulating behaviour and mass surveillance is **Orwellian and dystopian** in nature. However, the safety of China's Internet is also guaranteed. The **tension between individual freedom and amount of power invested in the state** hence becomes harder to navigate, as **the compromise between privacy and security becomes an issue of contention**.

Conclusion

- **Good governments must be prepared to make unpopular decisions.**
- Ultimately, however, **due to the nature of global politics and the ever-increasing trend of the emphasis on civil liberties and public opinion**, it may be hard for even good governments to make unpopular decisions, at least not on a quotidian basis.